> Tibet and China have never been under each other and will never associate with each other in the future. It is decided that Tibet is an independent State and that the Precious Protector, the Dalai Lama, is the ruler of Tibet, in all Temporal as well as spiritual affairs. Tibet repudiates the 1906 Anglo-Chinese Convention concluded at Peking on the 27th April 1906…as she did not send a representative for this Convention, nor did she affix her seal on it. It is therefore decided that this is not binding on the three governments.[16]

The 1906 Anglo-Chinese Convention stated that 'the Government of Great Britain engages not to annex Tibetan territory or to interfere in the administration of Tibet. The Government of China also undertakes not to permit any other foreign State to interfere with the territory or internal administration of Tibet.'[17] But Britain was entitled to lay down telegraph lines connecting Tibet with India. Tibet's communications with the outside world continued to be mainly via British India, not China.

The 1906 Anglo-Chinese Convention could be interpreted as British recognition of Chinese suzerainty over Tibet, but it was meant mainly to confirm Tibet's status as a neutral buffer zone between British India and the Russian empire. Therefore, the British could not agree to Lönchen Shatra's demand to repudiate the 1906 Anglo-Chinese Convention and recognize Tibet as a fully independent nation. Furthermore, a recognition of Tibet's independence would also be in violation of the 1907 Anglo-Russian Convention, which was concluded to settle disputes between Britain and Russia over spheres of influence in Persia, Afghanistan, and Tibet.[18] Under the terms of that Convention, both sides had pledged not to enter into any agreement with Tibet unless done through Chinese mediation. And China would not be willing to discuss the issue of Tibetan independence.

According to Charles Bell, there were also other reasons why the British were unwilling to concede to Lönchen Shatra's demands: the danger that an independent Tibet 'might be driven to seek assistance from Mongolia, and through Mongolia from Russia'.[19] As Pradip Phanjoubam, the editor of the *Imphal Free Press*, a newspaper in the northeastern Indian state of Manipur, has pointed out: 'British Tibet policy at the time was determined not by any fear of the Chinese, but of the Russians, in what was referred to as the Great Game.'[20]

The Chinese were actually not seen as important players in the Great Game, the struggle between Russia and Britain for hegemony over Central Asia, and they were invited to Shimla mainly because of the terms of the Anglo-Russian Convention signed in 1907, which, according to